

SUPPORT THE PATIENT TAKING LONG-TERM MEDICATION

Assess the patient taking long-term medication

Assess	Note
Adherence	- Ask patient open ended questions like "What makes it difficult for you to take your treatment? Do you sometimes find it difficult to remember to take your medication? How many doses have you missed this week?" Encourage patient to open up with statements like "We all miss doses now and then". - Ask about factors that may influence adherence: - Is the cost of clinic visits a problem (like transport, loss of income for the day, paying another person to take on responsibilities at home). - Is the time it takes to visit clinic a problem (like time away from work, home, responsibilities). - Are medications causing any side effects? If patient stopped taking ART because of a side effect, refer to doctor to review to switch out responsible medications ↗ 116. - Is there difficulty taking the medications (like do they taste terrible, are they difficult to swallow, is food available so meds aren't taken on empty stomach). - Is disclosure an issue? Is patient trying to keep treatment a secret at home? - Is patient feeling well enough to take medications (like is there a problem with nausea, diarrhoea, constipation or heart burn). Manage on symptom pages. - Is there a problem with understanding: check patient knows his/her diagnosis and understands his/her condition and what it means to be well controlled.
Recent illness	Ask about and document recent infection/s or illness. Manage other symptoms as on symptoms pages. Test for TB if cough, weight loss, night sweats or fever ↗ 92.
Correct doses	- Ask patient to show you his/her pills and tell you the dose and how often s/he should take it. Check patient knows how the medication works and why it is important to take it as advised. - Check that dose is correct for weight.
Drug interactions	- Review other medications that patient may be on and check for known interactions: especially ART, TB and epilepsy treatment, contraceptives and other common medications like: calcium, iron, zinc, antacids, metformin. Consult the South African Medicines Formulary (SAMF), use web-based drug interaction checker² (see QR code) or MIC helpline (021) 406 6829 if unsure. - Ask if patient is taking herbal/traditional medications. Discuss with MIC helpline (021) 406 6829 if unsure.
Resistance to treatment	If on TB or HIV treatment, consider drug resistance if other causes have been excluded and patient is adherent. Discuss with HIV hotline ↗ 178.
Daily routine	Ask about patient's daily routine and if it causes difficulty with adherence. Identify opportunities that can be used as reminders to take medication.
Support	Ask if patient receives support from family, friends or others in the community.
Mental health	In the past month, has patient: 1) felt down, depressed, hopeless or 2) felt little interest or pleasure in doing things? If yes to either ↗ 143. If stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
Alcohol/drug use	In the past year, has patient: 1) drunk ≥ 4 drinks ¹ /session, 2) used illegal drugs or 3) misused prescription or over-the-counter medications? If yes to any ↗ 142.



Check for HIV
medication
interactions

Advise the patient taking long-term medication

- Be supportive and non-judgemental. If newly diagnosed or poor understanding, spend extra time educating and counseling the patient. Explain the condition and the benefits of medication.
- If difficulty with adherence, avoid blaming patient. Rather explore his/her reasons for poor adherence and come up with ideas together to improve.
- Discuss ways to help patient to remember to take medication, like diaries, alarms, pill boxes. Use reminders that form part of daily routine.
- Explain that good adherence is taking medication at the correct dose and time every day, and will improve control and reduce risk of long-term complications.
- Encourage patient to involve partner or family member in his/her treatment.

Treat the patient taking long-term medication

- Refer for extra support: if challenges taking/remembering to take treatment, refer to counsellor for enhanced adherence counselling (EAC). Consider linking with a support group, treatment buddy, or community health worker.
- Try to keep medication regimen simple with as few tablets and doses as possible. Use fixed dose combination tablets if available. Avoid changing medications or doses without good reason.
- Involve patient in his/her treatment plan and adapt treatment schedule to daily routine as much as possible. Schedule appointments on days and times that suit the patient.
- If difficulty with adherence, see the patient more frequently (e.g. weekly instead of monthly).

¹One drink is 1 tot of spirits, or 1 small glass (125mL) of wine or 1 can/bottle (330mL) of beer. ²www.hiv-druginteractions.org/checker